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GOP senator lambastes Lightfoot

At hearing, Kennedy attempts to turn focus away from Blanche

By Alice Yin and Dan Petrella
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Former Chicago Mayor Lori Lightfoot was singled out by a Republican senator on Wednesday as someone who should not be put in “charge of a ham sandwich” during acting Attorney General Todd Blanche’s confirmation hearing.

Blanche, President Donald Trump’s former personal attorney who has been leading the Justice Department on an interim basis, was expected to face fresh scrutiny during a Senate Judiciary Committee hearing over politicizing the law

MORE COVERAGE: Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche faced skeptical questioning at a Senate confirmation hearing. **Nation & World, Page B4**

enforcement arm against the president’s enemies and other controversies.

But Blanche also benefited from a friendly face, Republican U.S. Sen. John Kennedy from Louisiana, who sought to turn the focus of the hearing to instead attacking Lightfoot, a Democrat who had a stint as a federal prosecutor before her single mayoral term that ended in 2023.

The two sought to paint her as soft on crime and incompetent, leading the former mayor — who is always eager to pounce on Republicans — to point the finger back at the two Trump allies.

“Consider the source: an unrepentant racist remarks on the tenure of a Black female former mayor of the third largest city in the country,” Lightfoot retorted in a statement Wednesday afternoon. “What do you think is going to come out of his mouth? A whole lot of ignorance.”

Kennedy had brought up a letter

See **HEARING** on Page A2



Sen. John Kennedy, R-Louisiana, questions Todd Blanche, the acting attorney general and President Donald Trump’s pick to take the job permanently, at his confirmation hearing before the Senate Judiciary Committee on Wednesday. **KENNY HOLSTON/THE NEW YORK TIMES**



Alfonso Seiva, center, holds a protest sign created by artist and activist Liliana Medina, right, as demonstrators and area residents gather in Chicago’s Little Village neighborhood to pray on Wednesday for people killed by Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents in the past year. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ICE enforcement escalates as communities mourn deaths

DHS issued directive to pause vehicle stops by agents, but Trump says they should continue

By Laura Rodríguez Presa
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As communities across the city and country gather for vigils and rallies to mourn the recent fatal shootings by ICE of two immigrant fathers during traffic stops, federal immigration agents around Chicago and surrounding suburbs continue to approach motorists during their operations.

This week, rapid response teams have documented at least four encounters in which federal agents approached people while they were in their vehicles, including one in Chicago’s Austin neighborhood on Tuesday and another in the parking lot of a South Loop supermarket on Wednesday morning.

Traffic stops by ICE have become the subject of public discrepancy between President Donald Trump and the Department of Homeland Security over whether agents should continue targeting motorists.

The department earlier this week had issued a directive to pause most vehicle stops after motorists in Texas in Maine were shot and killed by ICE officers within a matter of days. But on early Wednesday morning, Trump praised ICE on his social media site Truth Social that ICE was “doing a GREAT job” and that its work “has to be done.” He argued ICE should continue traffic stops, one of its most effective

See **ICE** on Page A7



People on Wednesday place candles at a makeshift memorial for Joao Sebastian Durán Guerrero, a 26-year-old Colombian immigrant who was fatally shot by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents in Biddeford, Maine. **RYAN MURPHY/GETTY**

CPS will lay off 760 teachers, other staff

District looks to close massive deficit with job reductions, furlough days

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago Public Schools leaders unveiled a proposed budget Wednesday with layoffs of 760 teachers and 801 school-based support staff, along with five furlough days, to help close a \$732 million deficit.

Some of the layoffs are the result of the district reducing its student-to-teacher allocation ratio by one, a cost-saving measure first outlined in May. The rest are part of the district’s annual budgeting process, where school leaders reevaluate staffing based on shifting student needs.

This year is one of the district’s toughest budget seasons in a decade. CPS leaders say they’ve tried to shield classrooms from direct cuts, but three consecutive years of trimming central office and department budgets have made that harder. The district laid off 162 central office and citywide workers Friday before releasing the \$9.88 billion spending plan this week.

If more money doesn’t materialize from the city or the state, CPS will convert five paid professional development days into furlough days next winter. All are non-attendance days, which means they won’t affect students’ instructional time.

“The budget we present today is balanced, but getting there was not easy, and some difficult decisions were made,” CPS CEO Macquiline King said in a news briefing Wednesday.

The perennially cash-strapped district last resorted to the tactic in

See **CPS** on Page A4

MORE COVERAGE: Cook County will ‘explore’ making Chicago Public Schools eligible for late property tax loan. **Chicagoland, Page A4**

INSIDE

Council OK’s \$425M for Fire stadium site

Aldermen approved a plan Wednesday to spend \$425 million in taxpayer money to spark development at The 78, the downtown lot where the Chicago Fire have starting building a soccer stadium. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

Long-running saga still in progress

The 10-year reunion of the Cubs’ 2016 championship team is a reminder that the chase for sustained success continues, writes Paul Sullivan. **Sports**

Iran and US step up strikes across the Middle East

Central Command: Merchant ship hit to enforce blockade

By Jon Gambrell
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — The U.S. reimposed a naval blockade on Iran and intensified its airstrike campaign Wednesday in retaliation for Tehran’s attacks on ships trying to pass through

the Strait of Hormuz. The American strikes hit an Iranian army barracks, killed at least seven troops and wounded hundreds of people across the country, Iranian officials said.

Days of back-and-forth strikes by the U.S. and Iran across the Middle East — and renewed threats to the waterway crucial to global energy supplies — have shredded the interim deal to end the conflict, and the region could tip back into all-out war.

The U.S. first imposed a blockade in April and then lifted it last month after signing the interim deal that paused the fighting and set a 60-day period for negotiations over issues such as Iran’s nuclear program. Those talks have stalled as fighting over the Strait of Hormuz has intensified.

When the U.S. and Israel launched the war on Iran on Feb. 28, Tehran effectively closed the waterway to shipping — sending the price of oil, fertilizer and many

other goods soaring far beyond the region and gave Iran major leverage in negotiations. The rising prices pose a challenge to President Donald Trump and his Republican Party, which hope to retain control of Congress in elections in November.

About 24 hours after the blockade went into effect, the U.S. military opened fire on and disabled a merchant vessel Wednesday.

See **IRAN** on Page A12

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 92 L: 72 **FRI.** H: 90 L: 74 **SAT.** H: 92 L: 70
Complete details on Page A14

INDEX

Almanac A12
Arts & Living B7
Comics B12-B13
Crossword B13
Editorials A9
Horoscope B12
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A12
Television B11

179th year No. 197
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